

Capacity Sharing Accelerator

Inception Report

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Acronyms

AARINENA	Association of Agricultural Research Institutions in the Near East and North Africa
ACIAR	Australian Centre for International Agricultural Research
AFAAS	African Forum for Agricultural Advisory Services
AFESD	Arab Fund for Economic and Social Development
AGRA	Alliance for a Green Revolution in Africa
AoW	Area of Work
APAARI	Asia-Pacific Association of Agricultural Research Institutions
API	Application Programming Interface
AR4D	Agricultural Research for Development
ASARECA	Association for Strengthening Agricultural Research in Eastern and Central Africa
ASTI	Agricultural Science and Technology Indicators
BMGF	Bill & Melinda Gates Foundation
BMZ	Bundesministerium für wirtschaftliche Zusammenarbeit und Entwicklung (German Federal Ministry for Economic Cooperation and Development)
CA	Comparative Advantage
CAAS	Chinese Academy of Agricultural Sciences
CapDev	Capacity Development
CapSha	Capacity Sharing
CBLP	Collaborative Breeding Leadership Program
CCARDESA	Centre for Coordination of Agricultural Research and Development for Southern Africa
CEIRD	Centre of Education Innovation and Research for Development
CGIAR	Consultative Group on International Agricultural Research
CIFOR	Center for International Forestry Research
CoP	Community of Practice
CoPSys	Community of Practice on System Science for Sustainable Agrifood Systems
CORAF	West and Central African Council for Agricultural Research and Development
CPD	Climate, Peace and Displacement
CRPs	CGIAR Research Programs
EIAR	Environmental Impact Assessment Report
FAO	Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations
FARA	Forum for Agricultural Research in Africa
FCM	Fragility, Conflict, and Migration
FLWS	Food, Land, Water Systems (FLWS)
GFAiR	Global Forum on Agricultural Research and Innovation
GIZ	Deutsche Gesellschaft für Internationale Zusammenarbeit (German Development Agency)
ICAR	Indian Council of Agricultural Research
ICARDA	International Center for Agricultural Research in the Dry Areas
ICRAF	International Centre for Research in Agroforestry
IFAD	International Fund for Agricultural Development
IICA	Inter-American Institute for Cooperation on Agriculture
IMF	International Monetary Fund
IOM	International Organization for Migration.
IRRI	International Rice Research Institute
ISDC	International Security and Development Center

ISNAR	International Service for National Agricultural Research
ISRA	Institut Sénégalais de la Recherche Agricole (Senegalese Agricultural Research Institute)
ITU	International Telecommunication Union
KOICA	Korea International Cooperation Agency
KPIs	Key Performance Indicators.
MELIA	Monitoring, Evaluation, Learning, and Impact Assessment
NARES	National Agricultural Research and Extension Systems
NARS	National Agricultural Research System
PCT	Program Coordination Team
PMU	Program Management Unit
PORB	Plans of Results and Budgets
RAB	Rwanda Agriculture and Animal Resources Development Board
RELASER	Red Latinoamericana de Servicios de Extensión Rural (Latin American Network for Rural Extension Services)
RUFORUM	Regional Universities Forum for Capacity Building in Agriculture
SAARC	South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation
SDG	Sustainable Development Goals
SEARCA	Southeast Asian Regional Center for Graduate Study and Research in Agriculture
SO	System Organization
SP	Systemwide Program
SSTC	South–South and Triangular Cooperation
TAP	Tropical Agriculture Platform
ToC	Theory of Change
ToR	Terms of References
TPI	The Partnering Initiative
UM6P	Université Mohammed VI Polytechnique
UNCTAD	United Nations Conference on Trade and Development
UNESCO	United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization.
UNICEF	United Nations International Children's Emergency Fund
UPLB	University of the Philippines Los Baños
W3	Window 3
WCDI	Wageningen Centre for Development Innovation

Executive summary

The Capacity Sharing (CapSha) Accelerator aims to transform how capacity development is understood, delivered, and embedded across the agri-food research and innovation system. The CapSha operates through three interconnected Areas of Work: the **Innovation Lab (CREATE)** develops and tests new tools, approaches, and business models to strengthen capacity across individual, organizational, and system levels; the **Marketplace (CONNECT)** serves as a digital hub that maps capacity needs and offerings, enabling demand-driven matches between providers and users; and the **SSTC (COLLABORATE)** area advances South–South and Triangular Cooperation by identifying effective models and embedding them in CGIAR and NARES programs to foster mutual learning and co-investment. The CapSha Accelerator focuses on strengthening individual, organizational, and systemic capabilities, emphasizing both technical expertise and professional (soft skills) training. Its core value proposition lies in fostering equitable, demand-driven partnerships and embedding capacity development as a central, strategic driver of impact on the ground, across CGIAR and NARES¹.

Building on the past initiatives such as CGIAR Initiatives/Platforms/CRPs, the CapSha Accelerator will innovatively deliver on CGIAR’s long-standing commitment to capacity development. Its structure and services are informed by lessons from recent initiatives, including the GIZ-supported Collaborative Breeding Leadership Program and three Gates Foundation – funded pilot studies in Ethiopia, Rwanda, and Senegal (2023 - 2025). These efforts highlighted gaps in conventional approaches and emphasized the importance of context-specific, flexible, and partner-led solutions – principles now central to CapSha Accelerator’s strategy.

The updated version of the CapSha Accelerator reflects significant evolution from its original design, shaped through extensive co-design and consultation with internal and external partners. These inputs helped clarify the Accelerator’s unique value within the CGIAR landscape, resulting in a sharpened emphasis on delivery and impact, and informed the adoption of a scalable delivery model tailored to varied institutional contexts and funding environments.

Current funding for the CapSha Accelerator is at USD 2.2 million for 2025. This reflects a minimally viable level of funding for the key central services described in this proposal. The CapSha Accelerator however has higher ambitions, where it aims to not only to deliver high-quality training and services but also to catalyze a shift in CGIAR’s research culture – where capacity development is seen as essential to scientific excellence, innovation, and inclusive impact. It aspires to become a go-to platform for advancing the science and practice of capacity development, scaling approaches that are rigorous, context-aware, and co-owned by partners. The Accelerator management strategy therefore prioritizes maximizing visibility and awareness of the CapSha offering, internally and externally, to ensure engagement with stakeholders, while driving a proactive and high-impact fundraising effort to support rapid expansion and scalability.

Looking ahead, the CapSha Accelerator will focus on deepening engagement across the CGIAR Portfolio by supporting high-priority pilots, scaling the CapSha Marketplace, and expanding capacity development offerings that meet the evolving needs of both CGIAR and its partners. In addition, the CapSha Accelerator has prioritized building awareness and visibility across the

¹ Note to the reader: we use the acronym NARES in a broader sense, also encompassing innovation systems (NARIS).

system and with external stakeholders, while laying the groundwork for targeted fundraising to support growth, and scaled and sustained delivery.

As an example of bold game-changing approaches that would serve CGIAR and partners, early high-impact ideas under discussion with partners include a Professional Development Program – a blended learning initiative targeting different career stages, including MSc, PhD, Postdoctoral researchers, mid-career professionals, and senior executives, offering both online and in-person training in areas such as management, communication, scientific writing, resource mobilization, leadership, cultural competency, systems thinking, and scaling science. Delivered in collaboration with partners like RUFORUM, regional university consortia in Asia and Latin America, and GFAiR for NARES engagement, the program would aim to build a diverse, skilled next generation of leaders. Annual cohorts could form part of a growing CapSha alumni network, fostering long-term relationships, peer learning, and cross-institutional collaboration that continues beyond the training itself. Through these approaches, ideas and efforts – and ongoing learning via the Innovation Lab and MELIA studies – the Capacity Sharing Accelerator will remain adaptive, impactful, and rooted in shared ownership.

Note to the reader. *The guidance provided for this inception report was at times better suited for Science Programs than for Accelerators. The reason is that Accelerators are designed to function as “oil in the machinery” of Science Programs, working **through** rather than around them. We have therefore adapted our approaches for some sections with this role in mind (and marked them by similar boxes).*

1. Accelerator overview

1.1 High-level Vision

Capacity Sharing - Accelerating Change Together

Capacity Sharing (CapSha) is a bold and forward-looking approach to capacity development, rooted in mutual learning, co-creation, and shared leadership between CGIAR and its partners, especially those from the Global South. As global challenges become more complex and interconnected, our responses must be equally adaptive and collaborative. CapSha envisions a world where knowledge, skills, and innovation flow freely and equitably across borders, through inclusive partnerships with communities and institutions at every level, rather than through traditional top-down models.

The CapSha Accelerator brings this vision to life through a cohesive, integrated model operating across three interconnected spaces:

- Innovation Lab: advances the science and practice of capacity sharing through research and the development of tools, methods and standards.
- Marketplace: connects supply and demand for skills, competencies, and knowledge via a one-stop web-based platform.
- South-South and Triangular Cooperation: cultivates equitable and multidirectional partnerships that invest in people, strengthen institutions, and reinforce systems-approaches.

At the heart of this model is a vibrant Community of Practice (CoP) with members from CGIAR and partners that links these spaces, fostering continuous innovation, peer exchange, and collaboration.

Together, these strategic elements position the CapSha Accelerator as a catalyst for systemic transformation in food, land, and water systems. By enhancing capacity where it is needed most – empowering individuals, organizations, and systems – we are helping to drive the transition toward more resilient, inclusive, and sustainable food systems.

1.2 Achievements from 2022 - 2024

Unlike other CGIAR Science Programs and Accelerators, the CapSha Accelerator is brand-new and does not build on pre-existing formal initiatives or structures. Concurrently, it is recognized that CGIAR has a legacy of capacity development efforts across decades, themes and geographies. The CapSha Accelerator is therefore uniquely positioned to bring together capacity from across the CGIAR system, drawing on lessons learned, existing expertise, and resources. Rather than expanding or enhancing previous efforts, it seeks to introduce new pathways for collaboration and capacity development, particularly in areas that have been under-addressed or fragmented.

While not a continuation of past programs, the CapSha Accelerator builds on CGIAR's long-standing commitment to capacity development across centers and initiatives. These experiences have informed the design of its structure, modalities, and services. The Accelerator's three Areas of Work are grounded in the evidence and insights generated by recent bilateral projects, programs and initiatives –including the GIZ-supported Collaborative Breeding Leadership Program, implemented in cooperation with Accelerated Breeding Initiative – and three major pilot studies supported by the Gates Foundation in Ethiopia, Rwanda, and Senegal during 2023 - 2025.

These pilots revealed critical gaps in conventional capacity-building efforts and underscored the value of context-specific, flexible, and partner-driven approaches. They demonstrated the importance of co-creation, peer learning, and locally led solutions, which are now central to the Accelerator's strategy. Instead of applying a one-size-fits-all model, the Capacity Sharing Accelerator integrates these real-world lessons to offer a more agile and inclusive approach to capacity sharing that can evolve with local needs and drive lasting, systemic change.

1.3 Description of intended research

The CapSha Accelerator's value proposition:

Accelerate the transformation of agri-food systems by equipping CGIAR and NARES² partners with enhanced individual, organizational, and systemic capacities.

Through a new, truly collaborative model of working together, the CapSha Accelerator strengthens knowledge-sharing, trust, and accountability – ultimately driving more effective, inclusive, and sustainable outcomes for communities and food, land, and water systems around the world.

The CapSha Accelerator is a bold new approach to developing and sharing capacity for transforming food, land, and water systems (FLWS). It is motivated by the **overarching research question**:

What innovative approaches and engagement models can mainstream Capacity Sharing in CGIAR and NARES to more effectively, efficiently and sustainably co-develop and co-deliver on research and innovation priorities in FLWS?

Grounded in mutual learning, co-creation, and shared leadership – particularly with partners from the Global South – capacity sharing moves away from fragmented, top-down efforts toward more equitable, reciprocal, and system-wide practices. It aims to strengthen capabilities at individual, organizational, and systemic levels through models that promote collaboration and continuous learning.

As pressures on food, land, and water systems intensify, the need for connected, strategic, and sustained capacity efforts has never been greater. The CapSha Accelerator provides both a platform for action and a research-driven effort to understand what works – and what doesn't – in diverse contexts. It enables more integrated, long-term approaches to capacity strengthening across CGIAR and its partners.

The CapSha Accelerator brings its vision to life through three dedicated Areas of Work (AoW) that integrate research, practice, and partnerships to strengthen capacity across systems and drive lasting transformation:

- AoW1 – the **Innovation Lab** serves as the Accelerator's research engine, answering the **AoW1 research question**:

² Note to the reader: we use the acronym NARES in a broader sense, also encompassing innovation systems (NARIS).

What types of capacity development products and tools are most effective at strengthening individual, organizational and system-level capacities and collaboration within CGIAR and beyond?

The Innovation Lab advances the science of capacity sharing through research on novel CapSha approaches, analysis of pilot results, and co-development and dissemination of CapSha tools for planning and measurement. The Lab will map existing models, assess gaps, and support adaptation to local needs. It will also generate evidence and guidance to embed CapSha standards, including South-South and Triangular Cooperation (SSTC), into CGIAR's science and partnership frameworks.

- AoW2 – the **Marketplace** serves as a digital and organizational platform to match supply and demand for capacity-sharing resources. It responds to the **AoW2 research question:**

How can a digital marketplace model be structured and deployed to facilitate matchmaking of demand and supply in real time, offering equitable participation and access across CGIAR and NARES?

As a one-stop shop, the CapSha Marketplace curates and connects capacity development offerings across CGIAR Science Programs, Centers, NARES, and external partners, enhancing visibility and access via the portal. In response to the fragmented nature of past efforts, the Marketplace streamlines access, reduces duplication, and fosters more inclusive, demand-driven, and interdisciplinary learning environments. By linking resources across and beyond disciplines, it supports the scaling of more systematic and integrated capacity solutions. The Marketplace would be the primary channel through which bold new offerings – such as a comprehensive Professional Development Program³ – would be delivered, enabling scalable access to technical and soft skills training for targeted cohorts across CGIAR and NARES.

- AoW3 – the **South–South and Triangular Cooperation (SSTC)** area focuses on strengthening peer learning, brokering partnerships, and co-facilitating engagement among CGIAR, NARES, and regional institutions. It answers the **AoW3 research question:**

Which SSTC models enable mutual learning and co-investment between CGIAR and NARES, and what conditions support programmatic brokering and mainstreaming?

SSTC aims to elevate science led by the global south and foster locally owned research and innovation pathways by enabling the exchange of practices, tools, and experiences

³ Such a program could, for example, systematically build capacity across MSc, PhD, Postdoctoral, mid-career, and executive levels – combining technical training with leadership, communication, cultural intelligence, systems thinking, and scaling skills. Delivered in partnership with networks like RUFORUM, GFAiR, and regional university consortia in Asia and Latin America, the program would cultivate annual cohorts of emerging leaders and establish a cross-institutional CapSha alumni network. This investment would not only meet a critical system-wide need but also strengthen CGIAR's global positioning in capacity development.

across geographies. This area deepens collaboration, mobilizes investment in capacity sharing for FLWS research, and positions CapSha as a driver of equity in knowledge production and use – closely aligned with localization agendas. An example of the CapSha Accelerator’s ambition to expand and scale includes co-designing and delivering professional development opportunities that reflect diverse regional contexts, which would be developed in partnership with actors like RUFORUM, regional university consortia, and GFAiR, supporting leadership and capacity growth across all career stages.

These three Areas of Work are connected and enabled through a vibrant Community of Practice and other CapSha community engagement mechanisms. This **cross-cutting Area of Work** answers the **AoW0 research question**:

How can CapSha’s Community of Practice and engagement platforms be designed to foster continuous learning, trust, and strategic collaboration within and beyond CGIAR?

It centers on engagement mechanisms like its Community of Practice (CoP) and knowledge exchange events, which foster peer learning, shared ownership, and ongoing collaboration across stakeholders. These mechanisms support a systems-based, non-linear Theory of Change focused on strategic brokering, incentive alignment, and mutual learning rather than linear pathways from research to impact. The CapSha Accelerator aims to embed standards, good practices, and services for capacity development into CGIAR programs, advancing a culture where capacity is core to scientific impact. Through continuous feedback and adaptive management, the CapSha Accelerator promotes more effective collaboration and long-term partnership health between CGIAR and NARES. The Accelerator is managed to remain flexible, responsive, and learning-driven – ensuring that its design and delivery evolve with partner needs and system priorities. Terms of Reference and evidence-based good practices for a CapSha CoP are provided in Annex 2 (submitted as a separate document which can be downloaded by clicking this [link](#)).

* * *

Together, these Areas of Work position the CapSha Accelerator as a powerful catalyst for systemic transformation across food, land, and water systems. CapSha is not just about closing gaps, but also about reshaping the global landscape of capacity development. By driving bold, collaborative action and fostering dynamic partnerships, the CapSha Accelerator will shift how knowledge, innovation, and expertise flow across CGIAR and its partners. It will be the leading force in building resilient, equitable, and sustainable capacities that drive change at scale. By 2030, the CapSha Accelerator will have made a decisive contribution to redefining capacity development, creating a ripple effect that empowers individuals, strengthens institutions, and transforms entire systems.

While the CapSha Accelerator begins with a modest annual budget of USD 2.2 million, it is designed for expansion and scale. By 2030, CapSha aims to have an annual budget of USD 5-10 million, commensurate with expectations of delivering across the CGIAR system, where it aims to catalyze a culture of shared, sustained capacity development across CGIAR and its partners enabling systemic change and long-term transformation in agrifood innovation systems.

2. Co-design and partnerships

Partnerships and co-design are foundational to the CapSha Accelerator's mission and delivery model. From initial concept development through its Inception Phase, the CapSha Accelerator has followed the principles outlined in the CGIAR Engagement Framework and Partnership Strategy - emphasizing equity, intentionality, mutual benefit, and the creation of systems and capacities that enable accountable, adaptive, and strategic collaboration across institutional boundaries.

The CapSha Accelerator views co-design not as a single event, but as an ongoing process that builds alignment, co-ownership, and shared value over time, see below. Guided by the CGIAR Strategic Approach to Partnerships, the Accelerator embeds partnership principles across its work.

Partner Engagement during Design & Inception

The CapSha Accelerator engaged partners through a focused, iterative process aimed at shaping both its vision and operating model. Instead of one-off consultations, it used a range of targeted mechanisms to gather insights, test ideas, and build shared ownership. These included:

- The CapSha Accelerator engaged closely with the CGIAR Science Programs and Accelerators throughout the Inception Phase to understand their capacity sharing needs and priorities. These insights were directly incorporated into the co-design process, helping ensure the Accelerator's offerings are responsive to programmatic demands and aligned with ongoing research efforts.
- In August 2024, a large online consultation convened over 200 stakeholders from research agencies, universities, regional organizations, and related institutions. The proposed scope of the Accelerator was presented, followed by breakout sessions where participants provided detailed feedback. Key challenges identified during the meeting included retention issues, gaps in non-technical professional skills, and the need to address power imbalances. These insights were instrumental in shaping the design of the Accelerator's next iteration.
- Following the online consultation, the CapSha Accelerator conducted a survey to gather stakeholder feedback on the Accelerator's intended scope. Respondents were generally very supportive of CapSha Accelerator's plans, but emphasized the need for clear baselines, strong partnerships and cooperation over competition, and inclusive participation of Global South partners.
- During subsequent months, bilateral exchanges and thematic co-design sessions were held with leading organizations, including academic and training networks (RUFORUM, UM6P), policy and intergovernmental bodies (African Union), regional agricultural R&D coordination and implementation agencies (GFAiR, FARA), and bilateral and multilateral development partners (BMGF, GIZ). These helped align CapSha with regional and global actors influencing the capacity development landscape.
- Large 2-year pilot studies in Ethiopia, Rwanda, and Senegal from a BMGF-funded project served as learning labs to test CGIAR-NARS collaboration modalities, identify systemic capacity gaps, and explore South-South knowledge exchange. These pilots also tested models for co-ownership and joint delivery.

- At a highly interactive CapSha session during CGIAR Science Week in April 2025, participants responded to a series of thought-inducing statements, generating valuable insights into capacity sharing priorities and gaps. They also provided written input on areas where the CapSha Accelerator should engage – and where it should steer clear – helping to further refine its focus. The results confirmed a clear appetite among partners for CGIAR to act as a trusted intermediary in knowledge brokering and the joint delivery of capacity initiatives.
- Another stakeholder survey was conducted in March/April 2025 to identify key capacity sharing needs (demand) and current institutional capabilities (supply), with the goal of informing the design of targeted initiatives under the Accelerator. By shedding light on both the challenges institutions face in accessing capacity sharing opportunities and the expertise they are able to contribute, the survey offered useful inputs for shaping future collaboration and knowledge exchange.
- At a highly interactive workshop co-hosted with Université Mohammed VI Polytechnique (UM6P) and the University of Wageningen, the CapSha Accelerator engaged with the newly launched Community of Practice on System Science for Sustainable Agrifood Systems (CoPSys), which brought together experts and university representatives from 12 African countries and global partners, including RUFORUM. CoPSys aims to advance system science approaches across food, land, and water systems, and its collaboration with the CapSha Accelerator is helping co-develop teaching modules, a gap analysis for Africa, and pilot projects grounded in system thinking. This partnership supports the CapSha Innovation Lab by embedding cross-disciplinary expertise and enabling South-South collaboration for real-world application of system science models.

Co-Design Outcomes and Design Adjustments

Partner inputs – both external and from within CGIAR – have meaningfully shaped the CapSha Accelerator’s design. They have helped refine the Accelerator’s focus, define its added value, and highlight areas for integration. Based on consultations and co-design inputs, the CapSha Accelerator:

1. Sharpened its emphasis on delivery and impact, aligning activities with measurable outcomes to ensure tangible benefits for both partners and the communities they serve
2. Clarified its role within the CGIAR landscape to add distinct value and avoid duplication;
3. Adopted a flexible delivery model tailored to different institutional contexts and funding scenarios;
4. Broadened the concept of capacity sharing to include joint design, delivery, and accountability, reflecting calls for more equitable and sustained collaboration;
5. Incorporated expertise from The Partnering Initiative (TPI) to embed effective partnering approaches and apply the CGIAR Partnership Strategy in practice.

Next Phase: Operationalizing Co-Design

The CapSha Accelerator will carry its co-design ethos into implementation, using practical tools to manage partnerships across their full lifecycle – as emphasized in the CGIAR Strategic Approach to Partnerships. Key mechanisms include:

- Structured bilateral co-design sessions with key external partners involved in AoW3, using a work plan tool to clarify roles, ensure mutual ownership, and define shared value.

- Through the CapSha CoP, the CapSha Accelerator will use informal check-ins and targeted surveys to capture real-time feedback, adapt to emerging needs, and embed continuous learning into delivery.
- A partnership health-check framework will track collaboration quality and flag areas for improvement over time.

Looking Ahead: Scaling the CapSha Accelerator through Partnerships

The CapSha Accelerator is already being explored as a potential coordination entity (in collaboration with CGIAR Science Programs and external partners) for larger externally funded programs focused on capacity development. These opportunities will require deeper co-design, co-investment, and joint governance – an evolution aligned with CGIAR’s Partnership Engagement Framework ambitions.

Importantly, to grow beyond its current core budget of USD 2.2 million/year, the CapSha Accelerator will need to ensure visibility and awareness of the CapSha offer in order to ensure stakeholder engagement and attract investment from funders seeking scalable, collaborative platforms for capacity development. Success will hinge on maintaining a focused, value-driven approach to partnerships, closely adhering to the principles from the CGIAR Engagement Framework and Partnership Strategy.

3. Theory of change and MELIA

Note to the reader. The guidance provided for this section – and the underlying ToC Board – is better suited for Science Programs than for Accelerators. The reason is that Accelerators are designed to function as “oil in the machinery” of Science Programs: The CapSha Accelerator principally focuses on guiding and supporting Science Programs in their capacity development efforts, working through them rather than around them. This means that the first “adopters” of CapSha outputs are often the Science Programs themselves (rather than their subsequent external partners). We have therefore – in close consultation with the SO – developed our ToC in a manner that reflects these more indirect impact pathways. Visible differences to “usual” Science Program ToCs are:

- Our four Intermediary Outcomes reflecting adoption and policy change by key CGIAR (and other) stakeholders
- Our principal 2030 Outcome of mainstreaming CapSha in Science Programs
- The fact that this 2030 Outcome links to all CGIAR Impact Areas and to all subsequent SDGs, reflecting the “oil in the machinery” approach taken vis-a-vis Science Programs.

3.1 Theory of change

The CapSha Accelerator is designed to catalyze, connect, and amplify capacity development efforts across the CGIAR system and its partners. Operating through three interlinked Areas of Work (AoWs) – Innovation Lab, Marketplace, and South-South and Triangular Cooperation (SSTC) – and supported by cross-cutting engagement mechanisms like the Community of Practice (CoP) and knowledge exchange events, the Accelerator aims to embed effective, evidence-based capacity development as a core function of CGIAR’s research and innovation agenda.

The CapSha Accelerator’s Theory of Change (ToC) adopts a non-linear, systems-based approach, recognizing that an iterative process is needed to ensure possibilities of adapting direction based on lessons learned. Rather than assuming a direct pathway from research to impact, it focuses on shaping the broader ecosystem through strategic brokering, incentive alignment, and the facilitation of mutual learning among diverse actors – including CGIAR, NARES, and regional partners. The ToC assumes that by strengthening the enabling environment – through research, platforms, and partnerships – capacity development will become more effective, strategic, and integrated within CGIAR and its partner organizations. Through this approach, the CapSha Accelerator is positioned to drive meaningful progress across all CGIAR Impact Areas and contribute to the full spectrum of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

Note to the reader: the numbering of AoWs in the figure below is automatically generated when exporting data from the ToC board and needs to be corrected in the final version.

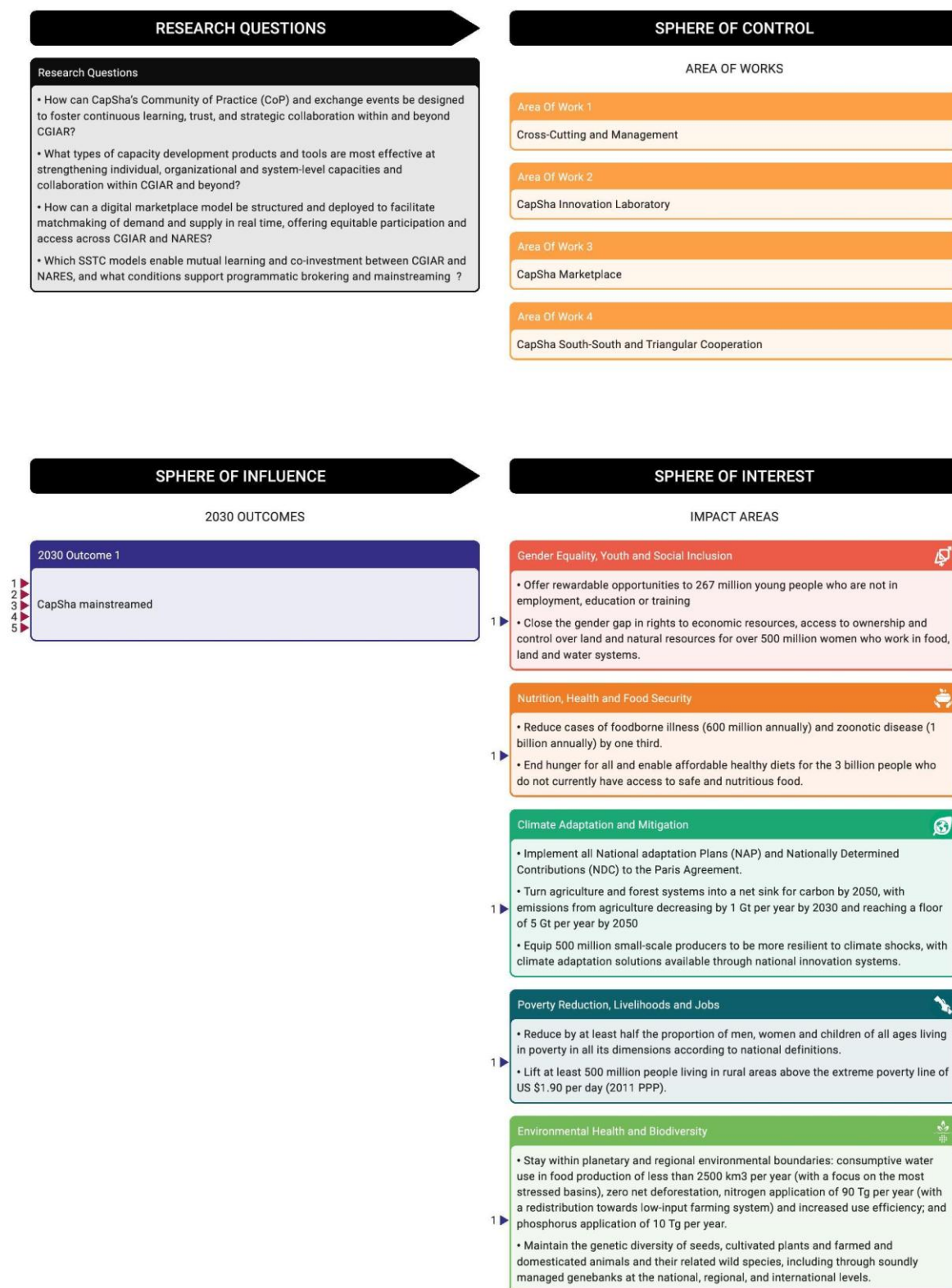
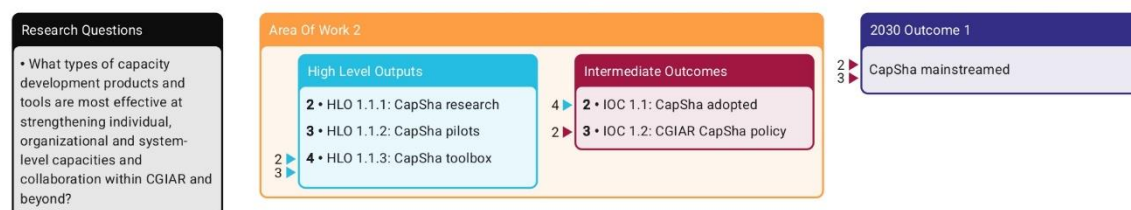


Figure 1 – Theory of Change

Each AoW delivers distinct, complementary outputs that contribute to intermediate outcomes and, ultimately, to the 2030 outcome:

AoW 1: Innovation Lab

AOW01: CapSha Innovation Laboratory

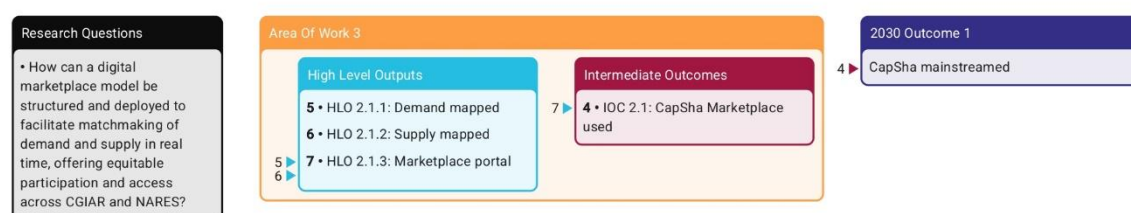


The Innovation Lab will serve as a system-wide incubator for generating, testing, and scaling novel approaches to capacity development at the individual, organizational, and systemic levels. Through co-creation with CGIAR Centers, Science Programs, NARES, and other partners, the Innovation Lab will produce practical tools, methods, standards, and insights that inform more coherent, evidence-based capacity strategies across the system. In doing so, it will:

- Strengthen the knowledge base for capacity development by developing and validating approaches in the science and policy research community that are grounded in research and practice in the CGIAR and NARES.
- Provide tools and frameworks that can be applied across diverse contexts and scaled through CGIAR and partner networks.
- Contribute to a more strategic and science-driven approach to capacity development across the entire CGIAR system.

AoW 2: Marketplace

AOW02: CapSha Marketplace



The CapSha Accelerator will establish a curated digital marketplace that matches the evolving demand for technical and other professional education capacity development programs (from Science Programs, Centers, and other partners) with the supply of offerings and expertise available across the CGIAR system and beyond. This structured, accessible interface will empower users to make informed choices, facilitate matchmaking, and unlock underutilized capacity resources. In doing so, the CapSha Accelerator will:

- Enable Science Programs, CGIAR Centers, NARES, and regional networks to both access and contribute to a shared pool of high-quality tools, services, and knowledge products.
- Foster a more dynamic and demand-driven approach to capacity development, moving beyond fragmented or one-size-fits-all interventions.

The Marketplace will thus function as a core mechanism for accelerating knowledge flows and match-making collaboration between supply and demand, underpinning a more integrated and responsive capacity development ecosystem in the CGIAR and beyond.

AoW 3: South-South and Triangular Cooperation (SSTC)

AOW03: CapSha South-South and Triangular Cooperation



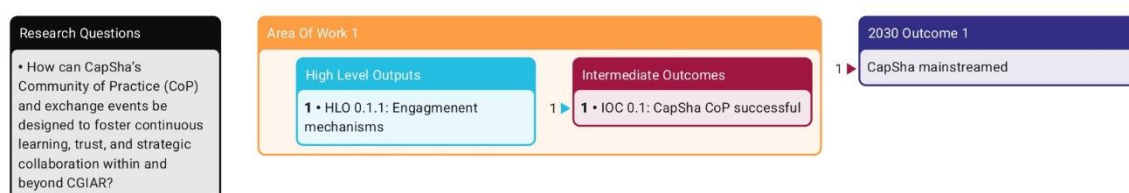
The CapSha Accelerator will elevate SSTC to a core modality within CGIAR’s global engagement strategy. By mapping key actors (including players outside the R&D ecosystem), analyzing cases, actively brokering partnerships, and piloting scalable SSTC models, the Accelerator will generate new knowledge and build the institutional architecture needed for sustainable SSTC. This will lead to:

- Increased recognition and adoption of SSTC as a valuable and effective mechanism for capacity development.
- Greater equity in knowledge flows and strengthened Southern leadership within CGIAR partnerships.

The CapSha Accelerator’s work will embed SSTC into CGIAR’s engagement models, supporting more mutual learning, accountability, and locally relevant innovation across the system and beyond.

AoW 0: Cross-Cutting engagement mechanisms

AOW00: Cross-Cutting and Management



The CapSha Accelerator’s engagement mechanisms – notably, its Community of Practice (CoP) and knowledge exchange events – serve as the connective tissue across its workstreams. These mechanisms enable ongoing dialogue, peer learning, and shared ownership among diverse stakeholders. By nurturing these relationships, the CapSha Accelerator will:

- Establish itself as a vibrant, well-functioning platform and go-to resource for capacity development.
- Promote coordinated action to tackle challenges, innovate, and learn as a system.

The intermediate outcomes from the Areas of Work described above converge toward a 2030 outcome in which capacity sharing standards, good practices, resources, and service offerings for capacity development at all levels are fully embedded within CGIAR Science Programs and Centers. This will:

- Advance the science of capacity development by providing a rigorous, evidence-based foundation for designing and scaling effective approaches.
- Contribute to a more learning-oriented and adaptive CGIAR research culture, where capacity development is seen as central to achieving impact rather than a secondary or supporting activity.
- Improve the quality of collaboration and strengthen partnership health between CGIAR and NARES, ensuring that joint efforts are grounded in mutual trust, shared value, and long-term sustainability.

The CapSha Accelerator's Theory of Change adopts a non-linear, systems-based approach. Rather than assuming a direct pathway from research to impact, it focuses on shaping the broader ecosystem through strategic brokering, incentive alignment, and the facilitation of mutual learning among diverse actors – including CGIAR, NARES, and regional partners. Feedback loops are central to this approach, enabling continuous iteration, reflection, and adaptation. The CapSha Accelerator's engagement mechanisms serve as critical enablers of this dynamic process, fostering collaboration and responsiveness across the system.

The detailed Theory of Change can be accessed through this [link](#).

ToC changes during the Inception Phase

During the Inception Phase, several refinements were made to the ToC to better reflect stakeholder feedback and evolving strategic priorities. AoW 1 and 2 were modified to provide sharpened emphasis on delivery and impact, aligning activities with measurable outcomes to ensure tangible benefits for both partners and the communities they serve. AoW3 was expanded from a narrow focus on piloting SSTC activities to a more comprehensive strategy that embeds SSTC within CGIAR's broader global engagement model – promoting mutual learning and fostering more equitable partnerships.

AoW3's brokering function was also given greater emphasis. Based on stakeholder input, the ToC now highlights that the CapSha Accelerator's contribution goes beyond developing tools and resources – it plays a critical role in enabling their uptake, aligning incentives among partners, and connecting actors across the system to catalyze change.

3.2 Monitoring, Evaluation, Learning, and Impact Assessment (MELIA)

Monitoring, evaluation, learning and impact assessment for the CapSha Accelerator will be embedded in the Accelerator's learning culture and activities will cut across all three AoWs, recognizing that an iterative process is needed to ensure possibilities of adapting direction based on lessons learned. Each AoW will monitor activities, outputs, and stakeholder engagement on an ongoing basis and save relevant data on the internal and protected CapSha database. This will in turn inform ongoing monitoring and evaluation of delivery of HLOs and progress towards interim and 2030 outcomes, led by MELIA support staff under the guidance of the CapSha Accelerator's Director.

Three key tools will be used for ongoing monitoring and regular assessment of progress:

- 1) The CapSha database for internal monitoring will capture the number and types of actors engaged, outreach activities, publications, events and similar information on an ongoing basis.
- 2) Annual surveys will be conducted to inform the annual CapSha conference event priorities and outcomes.

- 3) Two independent (i.e. externally commissioned) progress evaluation and impact assessment studies, in 2027 and 2030 respectively, will provide additional insights into the CapSha Accelerator's achievements over the years and identify areas for improvement.

The Innovation Lab will take particular responsibility for developing learning from documenting CapSha models and pilots, and from state-of-the-art CapSha science, and to use the learning to inform the Community of Practice (CoP) and broader stakeholder engagement (including South-South and Triangular Cooperation and the annual conference).

For details, kindly refer to the MELIA Plan that has been submitted separately.

4. Comparative advantage analysis

Note to the reader. *The guidance provided for this section is better suited for Science Programs than for Accelerators. The reason is that Accelerators are designed to function as “oil in the machinery” of Science Programs: The CapSha Accelerator principally focuses on guiding and supporting Science Programs in their capacity development efforts, working through them rather than around them. We have therefore adapted our analysis of comparative advantage in this section as described below.*

Moreover, we have also filled in the corresponding template, even if it risks being repetitive in terms of the comparative advantage argument used: the CapSha Accelerator is designed to cater to the CGIAR system, something no other partner can or is incentivized to do. The completed comparative advantage template is available as a separate Excel document.

The CapSha Accelerator's comparative advantage analysis has been a strategic exercise, not only in understanding what the Accelerator can do, but in clarifying where partnerships can deliver more. There is a broad consensus that the CGIAR centers, its Science Programs and Accelerators, and the CapSha Community of Practice collectively have the human resources, technical knowledge, expertise, and skills needed for the delivery of CapSha outputs and outcomes.

To better position CapSha within its broader landscape and identify opportunities for collaboration or strategic focus, the team conducted a detailed mapping of key actors relevant to its three core pillars in 2024 (see Figure 2), based on the earlier comprehensive mapping from 2016 (ref). This involved screening 47 government and non-governmental institutions operating at sub-regional, regional, and global levels, each with primary or secondary mandates related to capacity development in the Global South. The assessment categorized these actors based on their roles in research engagement, SSTC, individual and organizational capacity development activities, and coordination functions in the AR4D ecosystem. The resulting typology and interactive map have provided a strategic overview of potential contributors and providers that can complement and enhance the CapSha Accelerator's work.

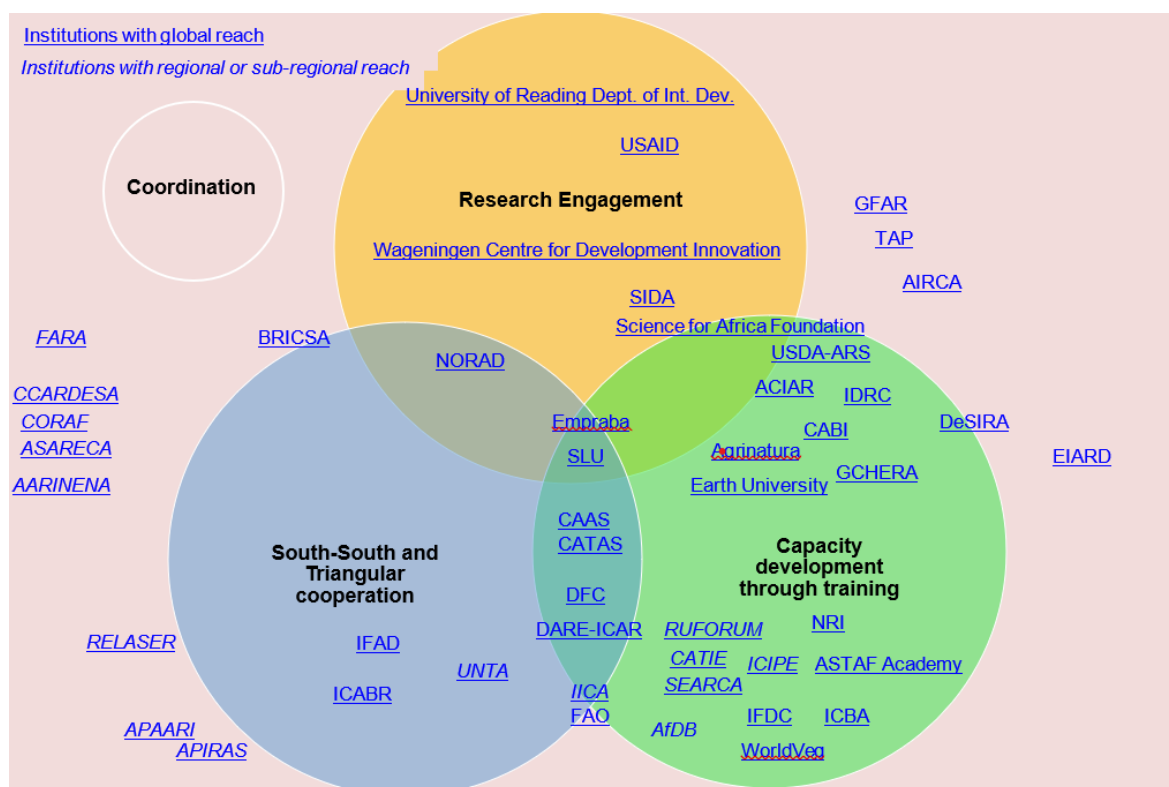


Figure 2 - Interactive map of providers and contributors along different engagement mechanisms⁴

The CapSha **Innovation Lab** leverages CGIAR's research capabilities to generate knowledge, tools, and innovations that drive capacity sharing and support CGIAR's shift toward systems impact. It combines its technical expertise with that of CGIAR's Science Programs to translate research into actionable learning. While CGIAR holds a distinctive position in linking research to capacity development at scale, several peer organizations operate in adjacent spaces and may serve as collaborators (or, in some contexts, competitors) in advancing this agenda. These include higher education agencies like the Wageningen Centre for Development Innovation (WCDI) and the University of Reading's Department of International Development. Think tanks like the Brookings Institution also influence the policy-learning interface, although with a broader development mandate. Additionally, platforms such as the Tropical Agriculture Platform (TAP) bring valuable experience in coordinating multi-stakeholder capacity development efforts focused on sustainable agricultural innovation in the Global South. TAP's emphasis on harmonizing training and sharing good practices complements the CapSha Innovation Lab's goal of integrating research into scalable capacity development approaches. What distinguishes the Innovation Lab from all these players is its integration within CGIAR's scientific ecosystem and its ability to co-design applied learning tools with researchers – linking innovation to adoption pathways.

The **Marketplace** serves as a matchmaking platform that aligns learning demands from within CGIAR (mainly Science Programs) with both internal and external sources of learning supply. The CapSha Accelerator's comparative advantage here lies in convening internal actors, curating content, and structuring delivery. This is strengthened by a review of global learning portals, which

⁴ Palenberg, M. and D. Bombart (2024). *Trends in Agricultural Research for Development (AR4D) Capacity Development since 2018 and Suggestions Going forward*, Institute for Development Strategy, Munich, Germany. (Available on request from c.kleinermann@cgiar.org).

highlights a lack of integrated agri-food-focused platforms capable of tailoring content to specific system transitions and user needs. Relevant external portals analyzed include:

- ACIAR Learn (<https://www.aciar.gov.au/aciarlearn>)
- AGORA (UNICEF) (<https://agora.unicef.org/>)
- FAO e-Learning Academy (<https://elearning.fao.org/>)
- IMF Online Learning (<https://www.imf.org/en/Capacity-Development/online-learning>)
- IOM e-Campus (<https://www.ecampus.iom.int/>)
- ITU Academy (<https://academy.itu.int/>)
- SDG Academy (<https://www.edx.org/school/sdgacademyx>)
- UNCTAD e-Learning (<https://elearning.unctad.org/>)
- UNESCO Open Learning (<https://openlearning.unesco.org/>)

These platforms, while offering high-quality content, do not replicate the CapSha Accelerator's envisioned value proposition, i.e. integrating science-based learning with systems transformation and convening capabilities. This provides the CapSha Accelerator with significant comparative advantage to complement, coordinate and lead in this space.

In contrast, the **South-South and Triangular Cooperation** pillar calls for more externally driven partnerships. While CGIAR brings world-class scientific expertise, other global, regional, and subregional institutions often have greater legitimacy, reach, and proximity to national systems. SSTC implementation will require formal partnerships with actors who have established track records in designing and delivering programs that transfer tools, knowledge, and systems-level capacity. Strategic partners in this space include:

Global Partners

- Global Forum on Agricultural Research and Innovation (GFAiR): An open, multi-stakeholder platform established by FAO, IFAD, the World Bank, and CGIAR, GFAiR aims to make agri-food research and innovation systems more effective, responsive, and equitable towards achieving sustainable development goals. It fosters collective action among diverse actors to shape the future of agriculture.

Regional Partners

- AFAAS: Strengthens agricultural extension and advisory services across Africa.
- AGRA: Focuses on scaling innovations and improving food security for African smallholders.
- FARA: The African Union's technical body for agricultural research and innovation.
- IICA: Advances agricultural innovation and technical cooperation across the Americas.
- RELASER: Enhances rural extension systems across Latin America.
- RUFORUM: A network of 163 universities supporting agricultural education and rural development across Africa.

Subregional Partners

- AARINENA: Facilitates cooperation among NARES in the Middle East and North Africa.
- APAARI: Facilitates collective action on AR4D in Asia-Pacific.
- ASARECA: Promotes regional collaboration to address shared agricultural challenges through research and knowledge transfer in East and Central Africa.

- CCARDESA: Supports SADC member states with agricultural research, technology dissemination, and knowledge sharing.
- CORAF: Coordinates agricultural research in 23 West and Central African countries to improve food security and livelihoods.
- SAARC Agriculture Centre (SAC): Supports policy and R&D in South Asia.
- SEARCA: Builds institutional capacity in Southeast Asia.

These partners bring complementary capabilities that enhance the CapSha Accelerator's ability to scale outcomes through SSTC. Their involvement will be grounded in a gap analysis to ensure strategic alignment with the CapSha Accelerator's offerings and needs.

It is important to acknowledge that the CapSha Accelerator is a brand-new entity, designed to serve two complementary functions:

1. Internal-facing: Accelerate the integration of capacity sharing into CGIAR's research and innovation portfolio.
2. External-facing: Actively broker relationships and create synergies with actors operating in similar spaces (as listed above).

As a newly established initiative, the Accelerator needs to build its credibility as a knowledge broker through purposeful stakeholder engagement and early, concrete demonstrations of value. Due to its current limited scale, it is not designed to function as an ISNAR-style think tank focused on capacity strengthening of NARES. As emphasized by ISDC, theoretical and academic work on capacity sharing is better suited to university partners. Instead, the Accelerator is best positioned to pilot, test, and refine practical models of capacity sharing, working closely with Science Programs and partners to generate evidence on effective approaches.

5. Prioritization

Note to the reader. The guidance provided for this section is better suited for Science Programs than for Accelerators. The reason is that Accelerators are designed to function as “oil in the machinery” of Science Programs: the CapSha Accelerator principally focuses on guiding and supporting Science Programs in their capacity development efforts, working through them rather than around them. We have adapted our approach to prioritization described in this section with this role in mind.

As one of four CGIAR Accelerators, the CapSha Accelerator focuses on supporting and enabling Science Programs and Centers. It achieves this by conducting strategic research on CapSha and collaborating with all other Programs and Accelerators, effectively “spurring impact across the Portfolio” and “bolstering CGIAR’s ability to reach and support targeted end-users while furthering collaboration, coherence, and integration across the entire Portfolio,” as described in the 2024 Portfolio Narrative. Due to this indirect approach, the CapSha Accelerator prioritization is intrinsically linked to the prioritization of Science Programs, rather than imposing its own additional prioritization.

In the CapSha framework, CGIAR Programs and their partners have the closest understanding of their respective capacity development efforts, and they are best positioned to assess strategic needs and make informed decisions. These stakeholders will identify potential capacity development cases, such as training on digital tools, professional education capacity development, cryopreservation protocols, or policy compliance, and evaluate them based on criteria such as strategic relevance, demand, feasibility, impact, and alignment with international standards.

The CapSha Accelerator plays a crucial role in supporting this process by providing facilitation, tools, and coordination, while prioritization decisions are made by the Science Programs and their national or regional partners. Once relevant actors establish priorities, the CapSha Accelerator offers technical and operational support to design and implement the chosen capacity development initiatives. This assistance includes developing action plans, mobilizing resources, and ensuring quality and alignment across Work Areas and economies of scale.

The CapSha Accelerator thus serves as an enabler rather than a program implementer. This distinction is crucial, as it prevents duplication and strengthens its mission to promote demand-driven and equitable capacity sharing instead of sustaining top-down support models.

With the partner-led prioritization for the CapSha Accelerator in mind, Section 5.1 provides examples of how ongoing pilots were prioritized both geographically and thematically. Section 5.2 then outlines our approach to prioritizing efforts across the CapSha Accelerator’s Areas of Work.

5.1 Knowledge-driven priorities

To exemplify partner-led prioritization, below showcases approaches taken for on-going pilot projects linked to CapSha. The first example showcases a tailored and context-specific process that was put in place for three large Gates-funded capacity sharing pilot projects in Ethiopia, Rwanda, and Senegal. This prioritization process was both rigorous and knowledge-driven, built through extensive consultation and collaboration with key stakeholders, including the national agricultural research institutes (EIAR, RAB, and ISRA), CGIAR Initiatives, and the Gates Foundation. It was specifically designed to ensure that each pilot was closely aligned with national agricultural goals, existing capacities, and long-term development strategies.

The prioritization process thus followed a clear framework that evaluated potential research concepts against four main criteria: a) alignment with national priorities and agricultural development goals, b) leveraging existing NARES capacities while identifying capacity gaps, c) contribution to CGIAR Initiative impact outcomes, and d) potential for long-term sustainability beyond the pilot phase.

The research priorities identified in all three pilots contributed directly to several CGIAR high-level outcomes, particularly in terms of increased productivity and resilience of agri-food systems, strengthened research and innovation capacity in national systems, and improved enabling environments for scaling and uptake. A key takeaway from the prioritization process was that deep engagement and co-creation with national actors led to more grounded, relevant, and sustainable research priorities. Additionally, the capacity-sharing lens allowed for a richer, systems-level understanding of what makes a priority viable, not just scientifically, but also organizationally and politically.

A second comparable example highlights a prioritization exercise which took place in the Collaborative Breeding Leadership Program (CBLP), which engaged 15 countries to identify priority areas for leadership and capacity development in national breeding programs. The CBLP used a tailored, partner-led process that aligned with national contexts, institutional readiness, and the goal of strengthening collaborative breeding. A total of 35 applications were received from early- and mid-career scientists across the 15 countries, with proposals focused on 13 crops and linked to five CGIAR centers. These applications informed the selection of countries, participants, and placement sites for both the pilot and future scale-up. The prioritization emphasized institutional commitment, potential for leadership impact, and capacity to apply process improvements in breeding. As with the Gates-funded pilots, deep engagement and co-design proved critical to surfacing grounded, relevant, and sustainable priorities. The process also reinforced the value of using a capacity-sharing lens to assess not only technical potential but also organizational and systemic readiness.

Although the CapSha Accelerator did not use the Excel template-based approach to prioritization (designed for Science Programs), the prioritization approach ensured that decisions were grounded in country needs, aligned with CGIAR's strategic objectives, and reflected the real-world constraints of partner systems. This process offers valuable lessons for adapting prioritization tools for accelerators like CapSha and provides a foundation for future exercises. As the Accelerator evolves, these insights can be applied beyond pilot countries to shape future prioritization in collaborations and partnerships across regions.

5.2 Final decisions on the Program/Accelerator's direction and design

Prioritization of CapSha Accelerator resources across Areas of Work followed the principle of “minimum viable budget”. This means that each AoW is scoped with a minimum viable product budget, featuring a baseline set of deliverables that meet core objectives while being strategically designed for seamless expansion as additional funding is secured.

Because the outputs and outcomes associated with the Innovation Lab and the Marketplace (AoW1 and 2) have a global public goods character, they do not imply geographic prioritization. Budget estimates for the Innovation Lab (AoW1) were informed by research time estimates and by the budget of the 2016 evaluation of capacity development activities in CGIAR, which included a thorough review of methods and frameworks in the capacity development space as well.

Estimates for the Marketplace (AoW2) draw on the availability of ASTI resources and a review of relevant existing online resources and knowledge portals outside of the CGIAR.⁵

Support to South-South and Triangular Collaboration (SSTC, AoW3) will follow Science Programs priorities related to geographies and capacity development subject matters, these will “follow” the prioritized work of these Programs. The baseline budget for this AoW is set to allow for the planned (global) review of the SSTC landscape and the facilitation of three SSTC pilots.

The Accelerator management strategy prioritizes maximizing visibility and awareness of the CapSha offering, internally and externally, to ensure engagement with stakeholders, while driving a proactive and high-impact fundraising effort to support rapid expansion and scalability.

Should additional funding become available, bold game-changing ideas under discussion include launching a flagship Professional Educational Development Program as a multi-tiered, global initiative. This program would systematically build capacity across MSc, PhD, Postdoctoral, mid-career, and executive levels – combining technical training with leadership, communication, cultural intelligence, systems thinking, and scaling skills. Delivered in partnership with networks like RUFORUM, GFAiR, and regional university consortia in Asia and Latin America, the program would cultivate annual cohorts of emerging leaders and establish a cross-institutional CapSha alumni network. This investment would not only meet a critical system-wide need but also strengthen CGIAR’s global positioning in capacity development.

Finally, it is necessary to again emphasize that the CapSha Accelerator differs from Science Programs and also from the other Accelerators as it does not build on previous CRPs, Initiatives, or Platforms, while it is widely recognized that the CapSha Accelerator fills a clear need by providing a structured model for capacity sharing and partnerships across CGIAR where investments in the CapSha Accelerator will enable cohesive efforts to build stronger, more interconnected research networks, accelerating agricultural innovation and transformational change.

⁵ For example: Agricultural Science and Technology Indicators (ASTI): <https://www.asti.cgiar.org/>; UN Trade and Development Learning Portal: <https://elearning.unctad.org/>; FAO E-Learning Academy: <https://elearning.fao.org/>; ACIAR Learn: <https://www.aciar.gov.au/aciarlearn>; International Monetary Fund Online Learning (IMF) Platform: <https://www.imf.org/en/Capacity-Development/online-learning> AGORA Platform (UNICEF): <https://agora.unicef.org/>; UNESCO Open Learning: <https://openlearning.unesco.org/>; ITU Academy: <https://academy.itu.int/>; IOM UN-Migration Ecampus: <https://www.ecampus.iom.int/>; SDG Academy: <https://www.edx.org/school/sdgacademyx> .

6. Alignment of W3 and bilaterally funded work

By leveraging the strengths of each funding type and addressing gaps through structured mapping, stakeholder engagement, and co-design, the Accelerator optimizes its capacity to meet the diverse needs of partners and stakeholders while advancing progress toward the SDGs. The CGIAR CapSha Accelerator's alignment with Window 3 (W3) and bilateral funding mechanisms aims to complement and enhance the core strategic work supported by W1/2 funding. According to the mapping exercise's Complementarity of Results criterion, W3/bilateral-funded interventions often pilot, scale, or contextualize innovations and approaches developed through W1/2-funded activities, ensuring that foundational research and capacity development lead to country-specific impacts. This complementarity represents a significant strength, enabling the Accelerator to fulfill its Theory of Change: W1/2 funds provide strategic direction, innovation, and cross-country learning. In contrast, W3/bilateral funds ensure responsiveness to national priorities and facilitate scaling.

For the first round of this exercise and with the understanding that there will be an iterative revisiting of the W3/bilaterally-funded projects, the Accelerator has selected the following projects that were mapped by the Centers:

1. [IRRI deepens its partnership with the Government of India through ICAR | International Rice Research Institute](#), (ICAR 2023–2027) relevant for the AOW 2 Marketplace; 2)
2. [KOICA-UPLB Project](#) - maps against AOW 2 Marketplace and AOW 3 SSTC
3. ISARC Phase III - [IRRI South Asia Regional Center](#) - for CapSha Accelerator can be directly mapped under [Centre of Education Innovation and Research for Development](#) (CEIRD) and is most relevant to AOW 1 and AOW 2
4. Arab Fund for Economic and Social Development (AFESD) - ICARDA Dryland Academy: Capacity Development - most relevant to AOW 3 SSTC

Some mapped projects will end soon and were therefore not selected, but harvesting results and lessons from these will be very much considered in the implementation across all the Areas of Work.

Additionally, there were also a number of important bilateral projects identified where there is already a close collaboration in place or initiated going forward. Examples of these important W3/ bilateral projects contributing to the CapSha Accelerator's areas of work are: UM6P-CGIAR, Germany-CGIAR PhD Program: Enhancing research, policy and scaling capacities in the Global South and CGIAR, upcoming CapSha Africampus proposal - G7, and CAAS/CG fellowship program, BMZ-GIZ Collaborative Breeders Leadership Program (CBLP). These projects were not mapped by the Centers and could not be included into the TOC.

A description of the mapped and collaborating projects can be found in Annex 1 (submitted as a separate document which can be downloaded by clicking this [link](#)).

7. Plan of Results and Budget

Note to the reader. Some of the requirements for the PORB section especially the spreadsheet 4 are better suited for Science Programs than for Accelerators. The reason is that Accelerators are designed to function as “oil in the machinery” of Science Programs: The CapSha Accelerator principally focuses on guiding and supporting Science Programs in their capacity development efforts, working through them rather than around them. We have adapted our approach to the PORB with this role in mind.

The budget was allocated according to the envelopes negotiated and agreed with the Centers. The Center budgets are divided into two parts. One is budgeted staff time for the Center selected experts to co-lead the Areas of Work for 2025 with 30% of their time and the other is a lump sum for work to deliver activities and outputs against the High-Level Outputs of the Theory of Change.

For the CapSha Accelerator there are no intermediary outcomes directly budgeted as the CapSha Accelerator starts new within this portfolio and does not expect to deliver any outcomes already from legacy work.

SO budget contains currently the Directors, the four PMU positions with a percentage of 30% assumption, the backpack provided by SO, and cross-cutting activities and deliverables like an initial evaluative study (baseline), the annual conference the setting up of a Community of Practitioners (see ToR in Annex 2, submitted as a separate document which can be downloaded by clicking this [link](#)) and other to enable necessary coordination and collaboration.

Some of the preliminarily allocated amounts to SO are expected to shift to Centers, e.g. the Directors position money to the hiring Center, once there is more clarity. Additionally, some tasks that are currently budgeted under SO, like the annual conference or setting up and maintaining of a community of practitioners have also the flexibility to be moved to a Center or an external partner or provider depending on where the expertise, staffing or infrastructure can best be provided to deliver the tasks.

It is important to note that the ICARDA budget is inclusive of the allocated to CIFOR/ICRAF to ensure that their expertise is brought to the CapSha Accelerator. This budget will be contracted to CIFOR/ICRAF through ICARDA.

For the W3/Bilateral mapping, we only selected four projects from two Centers. While other Centers had mapped projects too to the CapSha Accelerator, these were not a good fit, see also Section 6 for rationale of selection of projects. The Centers provided remaining project budget figures at the point in time May 2025 till the project end dates. We used the provided figures by the Centers that mapped the project, and adjusted the remaining budget to match the remaining eight months in 2025. We used an averaged budget per month times eight to match the given timeframe from January to December 2025.

For the Partners section we indicated a few examples of existing and upcoming ones, however, this is not an exhaustive list. Here too it needs to be considered that the CapSha Accelerator is only starting in this 2025-2030 portfolio with no legacy partner commitments.

As for the geographies please also revert to Section 8.2, the CapSha Accelerator will be with a global focus and follow the needs of the CGIAR Science Programs for geographic continental, regional or national specific needs.

Through the engagement with the other Science Programs and Accelerators and external partners in the space of CapSha, including the South-South Triangular Collaborations, the CapSha Accelerator will proactively seek additional funding, pilots and programs to embed and link up CGIAR's expertise with others. This will show in its evolution and budget over the coming years.

The full PORB is available as a separate document.

8. Cross-Portfolio linkages and geographic coordination

Note to the reader. The guidance provided for this section is better suited for Science Programs than for Accelerators. The reason is that Accelerators are designed to function as “oil in the machinery” of Science Programs: The CapSha Accelerator principally focuses on guiding and supporting Science Programs in their capacity development efforts, working through them rather than around them. We have adapted our analysis of cross-portfolio linkages and geographic coordination with this role in mind.

8.1 Cross-portfolio linkages

By default, the Accelerators have the mandate to work across all the Science Programs and other Accelerators. This has already started during the Inception Phase with a number of Science Programs, i.e. Sustainable Farming, Multifunctional Landscapes, Policy Innovations, Food Frontiers and Security, Breeding for Tomorrow, and Scaling for Impact.

The latter two are further described as examples in Annex 3 (submitted as a separate document which can be downloaded by clicking this [link](#)), illustrating their strong natural linkages to CapSha. Both share aligned goals and complementary activities that advance capacity development, resource sharing, and impact across CGIAR and beyond.

8.2 Geographic coordination

As an Accelerator, the CapSha Accelerator’s geographic priorities are closely aligned with and must follow those set by the various CGIAR Science Programs. Rather than defining its own geographic focus, the CapSha Accelerator works to support and amplify capacity development efforts where Science Programs lead research and innovation activities. This approach ensures that the CapSha Accelerator’s tools, platforms, and resources are relevant and tailored to the local contexts and priorities identified by the research teams and their partners on the ground. The CapSha Accelerator will follow the needs of the Science Programs in their geographic prioritizations.

9. Risk management

The risk management framework has been updated to reflect further analysis undertaken by the CapSha Accelerator team and to address the feedback received from the ISDC and key stakeholders. Lack of sustained and adequate financing and human resources, and compromised service delivery and adoption are identified as key risks, and will be mitigated by proactive and sustained engagement with funding partners and key stakeholders within the CGIAR system. Further, technological and compliance risks mean that the CapSha Accelerator team will have to invest significant efforts in ensuring compliance, accessibility and relevance of its tools and services.

We agreed that the CapSha Accelerator maintains four risks at this point in time. With its aspiration to grow and attract more funds for engagement in the form of for example pilots and programs, there might be the need to add an additional risk.

Please refer to the following [link](#) with the Program/Accelerator's full risk register. This link is open to ISDC colleagues and others will be granted access, on request.

#	Category	Title	Description	Current Risk Level	Target Risk Level	Actions /Controls to manage risks
1	Funding	Insecure funding horizon	A challenging global funding environment may result in continued under-resourcing of CapSha Accelerator, compromising the capacity of the CapSha Accelerator team to deliver, and generate competition for limited resources across CGIAR and National Agricultural Research Innovation System and Extension Service partners.	5	3	(1) Actively fundraise in alignment with SP and Centre priorities to ensure adequate financing of human resources and activities; (2) Demonstrate value of CapSha to SPs, Centers and CGIAR partners; (3) Ensure CapSha Accelerator operates in complementarity to SPs and Centers, not in competition.
2	Scaling impact	CGIAR environment hindering service delivery and lack of adoption	The CGIAR transition process may result in unclear coordination mechanisms, duplication of efforts, and tensions between SPs and Centers, limiting uptake of	12	4	(1) Regular engagement with Global Leadership Team, Global Science Team and the Centers' CapSha focal points; (2) Establish Marketplace and CoP with clear coordination mechanisms and focal points; (3) The CapSha Accelerator will contribute to talent retention and provides

			CapSha Accelerator services and the adoption of its standards and methods even in the face of successful delivery of products.			good practices to address continuity in the face of staff turnover and skill gaps.
3	Legal and regulatory compliance	Digital fragmentation and technological challenges	Lack of coordination and interoperability of multiple online platforms, tools and portals across SPs and Centers may compromise the quality of curation of content on the CapSha portal, and the functionality and accessibility of the CapSha Marketplace and Community of Practice.	9	4	(1) Consultations with relevant stakeholders in SPs and Centers to ensure design of Marketplace portals and Community of Practice online tools are aligned with existing platforms; (2) Regular engagement with SPs and Centers tech and community focal points to foster interoperability and connectivity of platforms, including clarifying Intellectual Property and sharing of APIs.
4	Business continuity	Mandate Dilution in a Shifting Landscape	Limited visibility of human and social capital in the global development agenda and the absence of an explicit impact area on capacities in the CGIAR system logic may undermine sustained focus on long-term investments in CapSha.	9	4	(1) Inform and support the development of CapDev goals and indicators in the follow-up to the SDGs and related agendas to ensure sustained relevance of CapSha Accelerator; (2) Build on institutional knowledge and lessons from failures and successes to institutionalize and systematize CapDev in CGIAR in the past.

10. Addressing feedback on select topics

Only one feedback (lack of information on how capacity sharing) applies directly to the CapSha Accelerator.

Concise summary of feedback	Details on how the Program/ Accelerator has addressed or will address this feedback (in the Inception Phase or beyond)
There is a lack of information on how water systems are covered in the Portfolio.	N/A
There is a lack of information on how climate mitigation is covered in the Portfolio.	N/A
There is a lack of information on how tradeoffs and synergies in mixed systems are covered in the Portfolio.	N/A
There is a lack of information on how environmental health and biodiversity is covered in the Portfolio.	N/A
There is a lack of information on how orphan and opportunity crops and pulses are covered in the Portfolio.	N/A
There is a lack of information on how youth and social inclusion (that does not relate to gender) is covered in the Portfolio.	N/A
There is a lack of information on how capacity sharing (as it relates to internal learning and decolonization of research) is covered in the Portfolio.	Capacity sharing is foundational to transforming the CGIAR system, not only as a technical (scientific) function but as a pathway toward deeper internal learning, equal research partnerships to be supported by equipping stakeholders in the global South with the needed scientific and professional skills knowledge at the individual level but also at the organization level in order to support skills retentions in the South and offering them the needed research support within organizations fit for purpose. Area of Work 0 (AoW0) serves as the cross-cutting backbone of the CapSha Accelerator, ensuring that principles of equitable collaboration, mutual accountability, and continuous learning are embedded across all areas of the Portfolio. AoW0 provides the strategic and operational infrastructure for internal alignment, adaptive learning, and system-wide engagement. The Community of Practice (CoP) plays a central role in operationalizing capacity sharing by connecting CGIAR and NARES practitioners across disciplines and institutions. It fosters a trusted space for peer exchange, joint problem-solving, and reflection on power dynamics and partnership norms. In doing so, the CoP helps

Concise summary of feedback	Details on how the Program/ Accelerator has addressed or will address this feedback (in the Inception Phase or beyond)
	shift practice and culture toward more equitable and inclusive models of research collaboration. The CapSha Marketplace complements this by offering a structured platform to broker demand-driven capacity development opportunities. It enables diverse actors – within and beyond CGIAR – to co-design, resource, and implement initiatives based on shared priorities. This demand-led approach creates space for marginalized voices to shape the agenda, further advancing the knowledge flows and strengthening system ownership. Together, these mechanisms ensure that capacity sharing is not confined to individual projects, but is woven through the entire CGIAR Portfolio – positioning it as a driver of innovation, accountability, and more just research partnership Making accessible and integrating scientific and professional skills knowledge within fit for purpose organizations capable of navigating strategically within a larger ecosystem, we believe that the CapSha Accelerator plays a fundamental component of it. It will be central in our innovation lab, where we will build on current engagement (bilateral projects) and actively search for additional examples of localized CapSha practice. Learning from these localized CapSha examples will help us understand what drives localized capacities, and generate the tools and instruments to highlight these, for changing the narrative from classical capacity building to active sharing of capacities within their political economies, and scale.

Appendix 1: Addressing specific feedback

Legend:

- Original response (November 18, 2024)
- Updated response (June 2, 2025)

Concise summary of feedback	Details on how the Program/Accelerator has or will address this feedback (in the Inception Phase or beyond)
Resource allocation To strengthen scientific credibility, the proposal should clarify resource allocation and team expertise, especially on the overall coordination and linkages with the Programs and the Accelerators (pp.15).	The budget allocations for Programs and Accelerators for 2025 are now available and the Accelerator revised its budget (see revised Section 13 of the Proposal document submitted to PCT) to reflect its allocation. The funding was allocated to the Areas of Work based on resources needed to kickstart the Areas of Work in 2025. <i>As a follow-through each area of work lead and co-leads revisited the budget again during the 1st quarter of 2025 and submitted a more streamlined budget allocation considering timelines, deliverables and considering programmatic and partner engagement consultations that took place during the inception phase which ended it up with the updated ToC and activities under each area of work as per the inception report. We also consulted with the different Science programs and accelerators to ensure complementarity, avoiding overlapping and ensuring building on each other resource allocations.</i>
Resource allocation It is unclear from the proposal what level of funding or full-time equivalent personnel will be dedicated to the Accelerator. This, as well as the experience and expertise of the team that will be responsible for delivering on the work, will have a significant impact on its feasibility and success. (pp. 83).	The Accelerator will look internally to identify its Transition Areas of Work leads and Co-leads, based on the expertise and experience available. It will also adopt the same approach to form the teams (within the limit of the financial resources available to the Accelerator) around these Leads and Co-leads needed to deliver on the work of the Accelerator. If the expertise is not found internally, the Accelerator will look externally to complement its teams. <i>The AoW leads and co-leads were identified based on expertise, experience and geographical and center representation. Tapping into the expertise of colleagues involved in the development of the design document, the CapSha Accelerator extended these opportunities to center representatives who are qualified and interested to support the delivery of the work of this accelerator during the transition period as interim up till end of December 2025.</i>
Resource allocation Better clarity is needed on the community of practice, how it will be operationalized and meaningful engagement	The Accelerator will develop terms of reference for the Community of Practice during the inception phase, clearly identifying roles and responsibilities, operationalization, etc. This CoP will include select critical stakeholders for CapSha from CGIAR and from Partners.

achieved whilst being mindful of time capacity of CoP members (pp. 86).	We have been developing and finalizing the CoP ToR and it has been included as part of the inception report as Annex 2 (submitted as a separate document which can be downloaded by clicking this link).
Proposal scope Narrowing the broad scope through gap analysis and priority setting would enhance effectiveness, ensuring resources are directed to high-impact areas (pp.15)	Accelerators are adopting a Use Case Approach to prioritization precisely due to their role as “accelerators” for the entire Portfolio. This Use case approach will enable the CapSha Accelerator to prioritize its interventions and geographies for high impacts based on CGIAR’s Programs and Accelerators “footprint”. The use Case methodology will be based on key principles and a rigorous assessment of CGIAR and Partners’ capacity interventions, interests in engaging in the use cases, capacities, etc. This exercise can only be done during the inception phase after the Programs’ own prioritization to allow for identification of strategic activities and gaps from the CapSha Accelerator’s perspective and ToC. We agreed that a more focused and strategically aligned scope is essential to ensure that the CapSha Accelerator achieves meaningful impact. In response, the writing team redesigned its ToC to prioritize 8 high-level outputs based on the consultation with partners and CGIAR programs during the inception phase. This will help ensure that our deliverables are coherent, synergistic, and directly contribute to system-level capacity outcomes rather than remaining fragmented or overly broad. Review of existing outputs and outcomes to align them with these refined priorities was also done.
Proposal scope The recommendation to the writing team is to tighten the scope and focus the work on strategically important activities identified to ensure meaningful traction and avoid fragmented and disparate deliverables (pp. 83).	The Accelerator will include a matrix analysis of Programs and other Accelerator during inception, to map Programs’ AoW and its own AoW, in order to define common interests in research questions or challenges, synergies, alignments, complementarities, and avoid duplication of actions. Based on the review made by the writing teams on the portfolio narrative of each Science Programs and Accelerators followed by bilateral consultations for ensuring alignment and complementarity during the inception phase, modifications were introduced within the CapSha inception report, the ToC and deliverables.
Partnerships Partner engagement lacks clarity, raising questions such as: was the Accelerator truly co-designed and how will the Accelerator add value to the delivery of capacity sharing beyond supporting activities? (pp. 15) The proposal could elaborate on how it will actively support formation of partnerships, outlining strategies for partner vetting and identification, engagement and	The Accelerator drew from evaluations since the CRPs and P22, which included extensive interviews with Partners on some of the ambition elements of CapSha. Although the Accelerator was hoping to further engage partners during the CGIAR Science Week that got cancelled, it was able to share its preliminary vision and structure with Partners during an online Stakeholders’ engagement in August 2024 as well as during bilateral meetings with partners that took place between June and September 2024. Some areas of work of the Accelerator were modified following the feedback from the partners (especially AoW 3 SSTC). More efforts will be done during the inception phase to engage partners, especially for the design of Use cases for the 3 AoWs, and for the CA analysis, which include partners as an integral part of the processes.

resource mobilization, as well as measuring potential engagement fatigue (pp. 84). The proposal does not fully address issues such as power imbalances, knowledge ownership, engagement fatigue, or cultural challenges in collaboration (pp. 84) How the Accelerator will ensure inclusive innovation and equitable partnerships needs to be clear to all partners from the outset (pp. 85).	The accelerator will build on existing engagement with science institutions, development and humanitarian actors, such as under the FCM initiative, which directly supports a shift in power towards local actors and knowledge generation through capacity sharing and co-design of research agendas and climate-smart agriculture solutions. Lessons from the CPD Partnership, for example, will be used to further develop new partnership engagement models for science capacity in CGIAR priority countries. In addition, co-creation and co-development are key principles for the CapSha Accelerator which will guide implementation. We agree that clarity on CapSha Accelerator’s partner engagement strategy is critical and we are utilizing various ways to ensure that we address this. The accelerator was co-designed through a multi-layered process that included bilateral consultations, regional pilot studies, thematic/parallel sessions during CGIAR Science Week, and a targeted Theory of Change validation workshop will take place at the occasion of the first meeting of the CapSha Community of Practice. This iterative engagement directly informed the CapSha Accelerator’s value proposition, operational model, and focus on joint delivery and two-way learning. To ensure the CapSha Accelerator actively supports partnership formation – not just activities – we are adopting CGIAR’s Partnership Strategy tools to guide structured co-design, partner vetting, and joint implementation planning. Mechanisms such as a “partner feedback loop” and a partnership health check will be used to monitor collaboration quality, adapt to evolving needs, and proactively manage engagement fatigue. Importantly, the CapSha Accelerator’s revised Theory of Change now explicitly incorporates principles of equitable engagement, including recognition of power asymmetries, knowledge ownership, and cultural dynamics. These elements are central to our evolving model of capacity sharing as co-owned, co-delivered, and jointly accountable.
Exogenous vs. endogenous engagement The design appears somewhat externally driven, emphasizing passive resource distribution, which may not fully engage intended users (pp. 15). A clearer framework regarding the scale and reach of planned interventions (including outputs), how these will be disseminated and used by different stakeholders will	These comments are well noted and will be addressed during the inception phase, especially while developing the revised ToC, the workplan, and designing the Use Cases for the Accelerator. Partner inputs – both external and from within CGIAR – have meaningfully shaped the Capacity Sharing Accelerator’s design during the inception phase - sharpened its emphasis on delivery and impact, aligning activities with measurable outcomes to ensure tangible benefits for both partners and the communities they serve - clarified its role within the CGIAR landscape to add distinct value and avoid duplication - adopted a flexible delivery model tailored to different institutional contexts and funding

help track progress. The Accelerator might benefit from a more active approach to catalyze capacity sharing with a stronger endogenous engagement and involvement that has been shown to be more effective (pp. 86).	scenarios; broadened the concept of capacity sharing to include joint design, delivery, and accountability, reflecting calls for more equitable and sustained collaboration - incorporated expertise from The Partnering Initiative (TPI) to embed effective partnering approaches and apply the CGIAR Partnership Strategy in practice.
Decolonization of science Articulating concrete actions for the “decolonization of science” and defining progress indicators would improve its legitimacy and effectiveness, making the proposal more compelling and aligned with CGIAR’s 2030 vision and funder expectations (pp. 14).	The Accelerator is already building on existing pilot projects and ongoing multi-centre initiatives. Those pilots would serve as one of the early prototypes under AoW1 and would generate best practices. Learning from those CapSha pilots' examples and the one's under development will help us understand what drives localized capacities, and generate the tools and instruments to highlight these, for changing the narrative from classical capacity building to active sharing of capacities within their political economies, and scale. Discussion has been taking place during the inception phase with CapSha partners in order to develop common progress indicators in 2025.
ToC, MELIA and Indicators of success It would also be helpful to define clearer, measurable outcomes to allow better tracking of progress and success over time (pp. 83). The theory of Change needs better detail to develop assumptions and clarify indicators that will be used to measure progress (pp. 85). The MELIA framework could benefit from more detail on qualitative methods and how MELIA will inform risk management. The multi-scale assessments, particularly at the household level might be overly ambitious and should be revisited (pp. 87).	The Accelerator Interim leadership is already working with the CGIAR PPU to address the issue of KPIs. The accelerator wants to adopt a two-pronged approach to MELIA: 1 level with basic CapSha KPIs that each Program and Accelerator can report on (which will go beyond “number of people trained” to capture a bit more substantive capacity change) and 2nd level that reports at an aggregate level for the Portfolio, which will be done by the Accelerator itself. This MELIA plan will include both quantitative and qualitative indicators and consider the most cost effective and practical way to implement the plan. For example, household level assessments will mostly remain within the purview of individual Programs, based on their own MELIA plans integrating CapSha KPIs along other science KPIs, while the Accelerator will build into its Use Cases the portfolio level KPIs. As previously mentioned, the revised ToC of the Accelerator will include more details on assumptions and indicators. The recommendation on using the MELIA framework to inform risk management will be adopted to refine the risk management framework. Defining clearer, measurable outcomes is crucial for effectively tracking progress and success. In response, we have refined the Theory of Change to include more specific and measurable outputs and outcomes, alongside a clearer articulation of the assumptions that support them. We have also developed precise SMART indicators that will be used to track progress and assess the impact of the CapSha Accelerator's activities over time through four dedicated MELIA studies, as described in Section 3.2 of this inception report and, in more detail, in the separate MELIA plan. These improvements will

	enable us to monitor progress more effectively and ensure that our outcomes are aligned with the broader goals of capacity sharing.
Comparative Advantage Analysis of comparative advantage of CGIAR in delivering key outputs and outcomes (rather than focus on inputs) necessary for impact and how this has created opportunities for new partnerships (pp. 84). The comparative advantage analysis could have been done from the perspective of the Accelerator itself as a new entity rather than CGIAR and assess its own legitimacy as a broker and its track record in stakeholder engagement (pp. 85). The CA could have been used to assess whether the CGIAR is best placed to conduct research into capacity sharing or if the academic work on this would be better done by collaborators with CGIAR testing the implementation and evolving best practice (pp. 85).	The CA analysis will be addressed during the inception phase in 2025 and will take into account these suggestions. While analyzing the CapSha Accelerator's comparative advantage from the Accelerator's perspective is valid, it is crucial to note that the CapSha Accelerator has a unique value proposition—directly linked to the science programs and mandated to support SPs in supporting/enhancing/facilitating/driving CapSha activities. Whereas individual Centres represent specific disciplinary domains, the CGIAR as a whole covers the entire spectrum of science-to-practice knowledge. This means that sharing approaches, methodologies, and tools from multiple centres allows for system-wide capacities to be developed and shared. This connection within the CGIAR framework enhances the CapSha Accelerator's legitimacy as a broker and strengthens its stakeholder engagement track record. Evaluating it in this broader context reflects its true comparative advantage and its role in facilitating collaboration within an established ecosystem that could have synergistic effect across CapSha related interventions.
Research questions The research questions would be strengthened by explicitly stating the underlying hypotheses that will guide the work and how they will help address the emerging megatrends (pp. 85).	The Accelerator will include the hypotheses to the research questions during the development of its Workplan, which will include more details on ToC, Areas of Work, etc. We have significantly reworked and streamlined the research questions. They are now underpinned by the assumptions formulated in the revised ToC these also serve as hypotheses (in terms of fulfilled assumptions) for the research questions.
Linkages with other Programs and Accelerators A concern is how the accelerator will effectively work with and build on other capacity sharing activities at CGIAR (with other Programs and Accelerators) without duplication or competition (pp. 85).	The Accelerator will include a matrix analysis of Programs and other Accelerator during inception, to map Programs' AoW and its own AoW, in order to define common interests in research questions or challenges, synergies, alignments, complementarities, and avoid duplication of actions. Section 8 of the inception report details how the accelerator would work with other programs to ensure synergy, and avoid duplication and support complementarity in terms of delivery of its service portfolio.

	As explained in that section, we note that the SO guidance provided is better suited for Science Programs than for Accelerators. The reason is that Accelerators are designed to function as “oil in the machinery” of Science Programs: The CapSha Accelerator principally focuses on guiding and supporting Science Programs in their capacity development efforts, working through them rather than around them. We have therefore adapted our analysis of cross-portfolio linkages and geographic coordination with this role in mind.
Area of Work 1 Innovation lab The requirement for development or adaptation of existing tools needs better justification with specific reference to assumption or drivers. It is exogenous in its description and would benefit from a clear strategy on how these will be actively used with stakeholders (pp. 86).	The development of tools, prototypes, etc. (called solutions in the proposal) will result from setting up the Use Cases of the 3 Areas of Work. Ideally, this would be co-created with Programs, other Accelerators and Partners involved in these Use Cases and would already bear some degree of endogeneity. However, we note that there must be a clearer strategy on how to mainstream these solutions within CGIAR, support wider adoption and an explicit mechanism to capture feedback from users to adapt the solutions. This could be defined as a sub-area of Work under AoW1 during workplan development. This is currently covered as an HLO under AoW1. Generating innovative research and analysis from pilots and use cases – leveraging insights from SPs and partners either through the SPs, accelerator, and the CapSha Accelerator itself – would strengthen endogeneity. This is further reinforced by the fact that all CapSha Accelerator research is done in close consultation with (and involving members of) the CapSha Community of Practice (see also Annex 2, submitted as a separate document which can be downloaded by clicking this link). The participatory AoW results would also inform AoW2 and AoW3, enhancing overall success. For AoW2 specifically, it would build confidence in terms of validated products, potentially leading to greater partner engagement and success.
Area of Work 2 Marketplace It could be strengthened by explicit plan for how it will incentivize and engage users rather than being a clearinghouse (pp. 86).	This recommendation will be addressed while detailing the workplan for this AoW. We agree to this comment and have included a dedicated high-level output specifically addressing how we can design, develop and put in place a mechanism to effectively engage and connect with the users. The AoW research question now reflects this participatory and endogenous approach, and the AoW ToC describes how it is addressed, including key use and “willingness-to-adopt” indicators and MELIA questions testing the related assumptions.
Area of Work 3 SSTC: a clarification on how the work will contribute to capacity sharing and innovation in different regions and context with clearer roles and responsibilities would improve the plan of work (pp. 86).	This recommendation will be addressed while detailing the work plan for this AoW. This is also addressed in Sections 4 and 5 on comparative advantage and prioritization. We note – as done in those sections – that the SO guidance provided for these sections is better suited for Science Programs than for Accelerators. The reason is that Accelerators are designed to function as “oil in the

	machinery” of Science Programs: The CapSha Accelerator principally focuses on guiding and supporting Science Programs in their capacity development efforts, working through them rather than around them. We have therefore adapted our approach to comparative advantage and prioritization with this role in mind.
Risk Framework The risk framework could be strengthened by including ... the sustainability of the Accelerator itself, financial, technological, compliance, service delivery, regulatory risks and uncertainties surrounding SDGs beyond 2030. It should also provide preliminary mitigation strategies (pp 86).	This recommendation will be addressed while developing the work plan of the Accelerator. These issues are now addressed in the revised risk framework (Section 9).
Additional comments Traditionally, accelerators are considered catalysts for action, helping projects or businesses to scale up quickly. It might be good to clearly articulate the definition of the Capacity Sharing Accelerator and clarify the use of the terminology (pp. 87).	The 3 Accelerators developed a common document defining the nature and the role of an Accelerator, which they revisited during the Interim Directors and Deputies inception planning workshop in November 2024 in Nairobi. The Accelerators agreed to engage with each other more, to further define their commonalities, their specificities, and differences from the Programs. This is critical in communicating with our audiences so they can accurately understand the Accelerators and fairly assess their contribution to CGIAR wide impact during the lifecycle of the Portfolio. While "accelerator" often implies rapid scaling in a traditional business context, the Capacity Sharing Accelerator (CapSha) has a broader and more strategic mandate within CGIAR. We are working to clearly define CapSha's role by explicitly framing its three Areas of Work: Innovation Labs (Create), which drive co-creation of solutions; the Marketplace (Connect), which links needs with expertise and tools; and South-South Collaboration (Collaborate), which fosters mutual learning and capacity exchange. Together, these areas reposition CapSha not just as a driver of scale, but as a catalyst for capacity strengthening, systems innovation, and equitable partnerships. Clarifying this terminology is central to aligning expectations and communicating CapSha’s unique value proposition.

For accessing the Annexes, kindly refer to the *Capacity Sharing (CapSha) Accelerator - Additional Annexes to the Inception Report* that has been submitted separately, or which can be downloaded by clicking this [link](#)

